

“We have players from all over the world. Our strength is that we work together. ... The union between the islands and the diaspora is what makes the difference.”

Pedro Leitão Brito, known by his nickname, Bubista, coach of the Cape Verde men’s national soccer team.



In Cape Verde, joy and worry

BY RACHEL CHASON

SÃO VICENTE, CAPE VERDE — Teenagers start arriving on the soccer fields in this island nation shortly after sunrise, as fog is still clearing, to sneak in drills before school. Early evening, they’re back on the pitch for scrimmages that stretch into the night.

In soccer-obsessed Cape Verde, 10 islands a few hundred miles off the coast of West Africa, many have long shared a dream: to play professionally for marquee teams abroad, and under their home flag in international competition. Now, that dream has been turbocharged by the stunning ascent of Cape Verde’s national team, which is heading



PHOTOS BY CARMEN YASMINE ABD ALLI/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

The small island nation of Cape Verde’s pride over its soccer team qualifying for this year’s World Cup is tempered by concerns about Trump administration immigration policies.

to the World Cup for the first time.

Cape Verde, with a population of about 525,000 and a diaspora about three times that size, is the second smallest country ever to make it to soccer’s biggest event, after Iceland. National pride is at an all-time high.

Players, coaches and fans say the ways that migration is woven into the story of Cape Verde’s team — and the nation — are especially meaningful in this moment of toughening immigration policies.

In the United States, which will host the tournament in June and July along with Canada and Mexico, President Donald Trump has led mass deportation campaigns

SEE CAPE VERDE ON A10

Iran is crippled, but Trump can’t declare victory

RESILIENT TEHRAN STILL HAS CARDS TO PLAY

President faces pressure to refocus on the economy

BY MICHAEL BIRNBAUM

After two weeks of war against Iran, President Donald Trump may soon be ready to declare victory. But he confronts a challenge: Tehran also gets a vote.

With most of Iran’s navy eliminated, much of its missile stockpile destroyed and top leaders killed, Trump is nearing the goals his military leaders set at the outset of the war.

But two weeks of conflict have not achieved the broader aims Trump has sometimes declared. A hardened regime in Tehran remains in power, and it is roiling global oil markets by choking off the vital shipping lane that allows oil and gas out of the Persian Gulf.

The country’s leaders may be more eager than ever to race toward a nuclear weapon, diplomats and analysts say. Iran re-

tains control of what the United States and allied nations believe is 440 kilograms of highly enriched uranium, giving it another chip as the regime battles to defend itself and endure the U.S. and Israeli onslaught.

The paradox poses a challenge to Trump’s ability to end the war as he faces increasing pressure from his own party to refocus attention on the economy ahead of the midterm elections.

Gasoline prices have spiked 25 percent since the United States and Israel began bombarding Iran, farmers are facing rising fertilizer costs, and the death toll of U.S. troops is rising. Tehran has proved resilient in its ability to attack ships that try to brave the Strait of Hormuz, making it unclear whether a unilateral halt to the war by the U.S. side would be

SEE IRAN ON A9

Some young voters have regrets about president over the Iran war

BY DAN MERICA AND CAT ZAKRZEWSKI

CHARLOTTE — Joshua Byers was hopeful when he voted for Donald Trump in 2024. The 26-year-old document clerk believed the former and future president when he said he would lower prices and improve the lives of the working class.

Over a year into Trump’s second stint in the White House, and overwhelmed with concern about the war with Iran, buyer’s remorse has set in for Byers.

“I feel betrayed,” Byers told The Washington Post after participating in a focus group of young voters outside Charlotte. “I don’t know why we are fighting [in Iran] if we have never been at-

tacked,” Byers told the group of around two dozen young people. “I just don’t understand why.”

Byers’s concerns highlight a growing sentiment among younger Trump supporters. Many in the focus group said they believed Trump’s pitch in 2024, helping catapult him back to the White House by drawing more support from young voters than any Republican presidential candidate in two decades. But with prices stubbornly high, a belief that Trump is overly focused on international conflict and concerns about how federal officials are implementing the president’s immigration policy, they also said they are questioning why they voted in the first place.

SEE VOTERS ON A7

Plane casualties: The Pentagon names the soldiers killed in crash. A9

Grenell’s fiery tenure recast Kennedy Center

Arts and music center became a flashpoint in Trump’s culture wars

BY GEOFF EDGERS

It didn’t take Richard Grenell long to transform the Kennedy Center.

The fiery former ambassador took the institution’s top post in February 2025 with a clear mandate from his boss. President Donald Trump told reporters in the Oval Office that the country’s center for arts and culture, home of the National Symphony and Washington National Opera, was “not going to be woke.”

And within days of Grenell’s arrival, he set in motion the changes that would recast a nonprofit known for presenting classical music, opera and ballet as a key player in the administration’s culture wars. The Kennedy Center that Grenell leaves (Trump named his replacement on Friday) is vastly different from the one he entered. Not only has it split with the Wash-

ington National Opera, the center has experienced reams of cancellations from artists and been abandoned by audience members disturbed by its direction. Those performances that still take place often play to semi-empty houses. And last month, Trump abruptly announced the center will close in July for a two-year renovation project.

“This has been hard to watch, how quickly he’s run it into the ground,” said one former high-ranking employee who was fired during the first week of Grenell’s tenure and, like others interviewed for this article, spoke on the condition of anonymity out of fear of retribution.

Sharp-elbowed and sharp-tongued, Grenell has often carried himself as Trump’s attack dog — lambasting media members, Democrats and anyone else he perceived as insufficiently aligned with the president’s agenda.

In response to a Saturday post criticizing his tenure from Sen. Sheldon Whitehouse (D-Rhode Island), Grenell shot back, “Your buffoonery knows no limits. You

SEE KENNEDY CENTER ON A5



KEVIN WINTER/GETTY IMAGES

A saintly night for the ‘Sinners’ star

Michael B. Jordan wins best actor at the Academy Awards on Sunday night in Hollywood, where the big awards were spread around. Coverage in Style, B1, and at [washingtonpost.com/style](https://www.washingtonpost.com/style).

Trump ally proposes new White House makeover

BY DAN DIAMOND AND AARON STECKELBERG

For nearly two centuries, the White House’s main entrance — framed by a row of graceful Ionic columns — has been a signature image of the seat of American power.

Now the Trump-appointed head of a federal arts commission is proposing to replace them with a more ornate style favored by President Donald Trump. Those more decorative columns, a style known as Corinthian, are considered the most luxurious in classical architecture and appear on buildings such as the U.S. Capitol and the Supreme Court. They have long been deployed on Trump’s properties, and the president has handpicked them for his planned White House ballroom, too.

“Corinthian is the highest order [of column], and that’s what our other two branches of government have,” Rodney Mims Cook Jr., the Trump appointee who chairs the Commission of Fine Arts, a federal

SEE COLUMNS ON A16

IN THE NEWS

Severe weather possible today An intense storm system in the D.C. region could bring thunderstorms capable of producing violent wind gusts, hail and tornadoes. B7

March Madness The fields are set for the men’s and women’s NCAA tournaments, beginning the road to the Final Four. C1

THE NATION

A dime that commemorates America’s 250th anniversary lacks a symbol of peace. A2

The Democratic primary for a Senate seat in Illinois will test two key forces’ influence. A3

THE WORLD

Pope Leo XIV, the first American-born pontiff, is turning to allies in the Catholic Church to help him manage split-screen messaging about the U.S.-led military strikes against Iran. A8

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Low housing costs once helped Nevada stand out, but affordability is now a hot topic in the swing state. A13

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A new reality dating series on Netflix tests the idea that age is just a number. B1

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U.S. paralympic hockey team wins the gold medal with a victory over rival Canada. C1

THE REGION

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Tulip Day festivities in Washington were well attended as people look ahead to the end of a harsh winter. C9

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During a trip to the Grand Canyon, a strange new ache marked the start of a 55-year-old man’s troubles. D1

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